

personal or professional life. The sweet lure of instant communication technology is stimulating, hard to resist, rewarding and thrives on the fact that most people don't know when to stop.

What was once considered a disorder for computer enthusiasts and college kids high on bandwidth is now a widespread social phenomenon. A report, 'Teenage Life Online', details the rise of what it calls "the instant-messaging generation".

Internet usage has multiplied many times over with the rise of instant messengers or IMs. It all began as a simple, quick way for teenagers to swap brief, synchronous messages over the Internet—make small talk, crib, complain, and flirt. But in four years, instant messaging has grown to become the biggest 'killer app' of the Internet after e-mail. And the market is growing every day: AOL's IM and ICQ services alone account for about 750 million messages each day. AOL's AIM and ICQ software claim to have 130 million users, while Microsoft reports 18 million users. Yahoo!, another leader in the field, declines to reveal its total instant messaging user base.

For the uninitiated, instant messaging allows you to maintain a list of people you wish to interact with. You can send messages to any of the people in your list, often called a buddy list or contact list. Sending a message opens up a small window where you and your friend can type in messages that both of you can see.

IMs allow you immediate, quick-hit communication, just like a phone conversation, and provide ability to converse with many people at the same time. IMs bring the best of both worlds, the expanse of the Web and the instantaneousness of the phone. This is why instant messaging has gained such unprecedented popularity.

Raahila, an Internet veteran, who started using messengers about two-and-a-half years ago to chat with friends abroad says it has become an indispensable part of her daily routine now: "My friends abroad don't seem so far away and that includes online friends too since they've become a part of my everyday life. It's an easy and cheap way to keep in touch."

Humans have an intrinsic ability to multitask; it's no surprise this seemingly benign technology has enmeshed itself into our lives. Rukmani Saradha, an EEE student, always keeps her messenger on whenever she surfs, be it for fun or academics. She feels that chatting has helped her know a lot about people. "I've got so many new friends—people who study in my college. I was not so close with them earlier, but after chatting I've come to understand a lot more about them. It's not just the matter of getting new friends, you learn facets about people you didn't know before."

Chat in the workplace

No longer just a tool for exchanging information and interacting, instant messaging has swamped

the workplace where professionals swap industry information and gossip—all in the blink of an eye. Instead of traipsing down the hall, making a phone call, or waiting for an e-mailed response, employees can communicate with one another via online text, 'pinging' each other questions and requests, speeding up reaction rate and increasing productivity. According to a recent Jupiter Media Metrix report, more than 11 million people use instant messaging services at work. For employees working on location and supervisors stationed outside of home offices, instant messaging is rapidly becoming indispensable.

Using IM at the office does have significant advantages, as long as it's a planned part of your infrastructure. For brief, immediate communication, it beats a phone call or e-mail. So what's the problem with free IM programs? Productivity, for starters. Are your employees gossiping with their friends or using IM strictly as a means of business communication?

Tripti Awade, CEO of Alnishsoft, feels that IMs have extended the professional grounds for her business contacts and considers it a wonderful CRM tool. But she remains sceptical about its purpose. "Chat should be banned in the workplace as it hampers productivity and slows down work, especially among junior members who tend to use it for whiling away time."

Picking favourites

The spillovers in the battle for the instant messaging market have left many users confused with a range of software applications. Yahoo! and MSN were clear favourites; many people loved Yahoo!'s feature of leaving offline messages and MSN for its simplicity. The early adopters, however, depend on ICQ because of the sheer number of contacts and applications possible. But heavy Internet users pick no favourites among messengers; they just turn them all on. Companies like Trillian, Jabber and Odigo provide some relief by making instant messengers interoperable.

Chandrashekar, an avid Linux enthusiast and long time netizen, uses GAIM when he's on Linux and Jabber when he's on Windows. Laila, on the other hand pledges her loyalty to ICQ because, as she says, "with ICQ you can see exactly what the person types without any corrections, it has a history log, and it's the closest you can get without actually being face to face. Yahoo!'s beta version is cool too". She was not too keen on chatting in public chat rooms though: "You hardly find any interesting people. It's like a free-for-all".

Messengers are getting more indispensable thanks to connectivity on mobile devices like cellular phones and PDAs. It won't be long

Get a Life!

A 10-step recovery program for online addiction

- Use a timer or alarm clock. Use software that keeps track of online time and Net usage.
- If possible, make sure your computer is not in an isolated room.
- Rearrange furniture, set things up so it's not so easy to lose track of time while using the computer.
- Have the radio on, perhaps a TV program that regularly mentions the time of day.
- Change your habits. If you tend to get online first thing upon awakening, choose something else to do first.
- Try taking a holiday, unplug every now and then and use that time to sort out priorities and goals.
- Make sure you finish all your important chores first, and then perhaps allow yourself some online time as a reward.
- Cultivate other interests, hobbies, and passions.
- Take a walk rather than sit down and log on.
- Turn off auto sign-ins, use busy signals, and don't be afraid to delete and block people.



Habbo Hotel: a virtual five-star hotel for teenagers